

which must be approved by the technical committee.

Costly affair

As far as wheelchair racing is concerned, the expenses are enormous, which is a major reason it has struggled to join the growing wave of para athletics in the country.

The cost of a decent racing wheelchair may start from Rs. 4 lakh, according to Ankur. He doesn't own one yet. "I share it with someone. For example, when the owner is competing in the 100m, I might race in the 400m," says the 33-year-old.

Anil Kadian took a different route before ending up in wheelchair racing. Affected by polio at a very young age, Anil discovered wheelchair racing during his college days at the National Institute of Fashion

Technology, when he randomly came across a video of Great Britain's David Weir competing at the London Paralympics 2012.

When Anil expressed his desire to compete in wheelchair racing to a coach at a marathon in 2016, he was told: "It is an expensive sport. You have to take care of a lot of things and there is no such facility in India. You can try something else since you have the power and stamina."

He tried his hand at discus throw before fate connected him with someone from Switzerland, who told him about an annual camp for wheelchair racing in 2019. "Switzerland's Marcel Hug, multiple-time world record holder, gave me one of his used chairs there. I bought it for Rs. 3.5 lakh," says the 34-year-old. From his savings as a freelance designer and the major

support of a sponsor, Anil recently bought a new wheelchair from the U.S. at a cost of around Rs. 9.5 lakh.

"There isn't even a single part available for these wheelchairs. Maybe that's why people in India don't want to get into this. We had so many hard-working people who left due to lack of funding. I am still pursuing it because for me, it is like an escape from all the hardships I have faced in life," he says.

Meanwhile, in track events in para athletics the use of prosthetic limbs is a fairly common sight, but for Indian athletes, getting to that starting line is not easy. Pranav Desai, born with a premature right leg, was using a prosthesis from a German brand. The same company organised a running camp in Mumbai in 2015, where Desai first learnt about blades. "At that camp, German sprinter

